

THE WORLD CUP AND ECONOMICS

Big Business, Small Macro

- The FIFA World Cup is the largest sporting event in the world, bigger than the Olympics, the Super Bowl, and the Cricket World Cup. An estimated 5 billion people watched at least part of the 2022 World Cup Finals in Qatar, and with more teams, more venues, and more matches, the 2026 World Cup is set to be even bigger.
- The World Cup is not only a major sporting occasion, it is also a significant commercial event. It will have important financial implications for companies across a diverse range of sectors, including sporting apparel, hospitality, and beverages. Our Equity analysts expect that the main sector beneficiaries will include European and US Consumer Staples, European Consumer Discretionary, US Retail, US Lodging and Leisure, and US Airlines.
- While the World Cup is undoubtedly a major commercial event, it does not necessarily follow that the macroeconomic impact on the host nations will be substantial or long-lasting. Only a portion of the economic benefit will accrue to the host countries, much of the spending may simply be redirected from other activities, and any rise in expenditure before and during the Finals is often followed by decreased spending afterwards.
- Using data from the 1982 World Cup onwards, we analyze GDP performance in host nations compared with a sample of 50 developed and emerging market economies. We find that there is a marginally positive but not statistically significant effect on the real GDP of the host nation during the year the World Cup takes place and the long-run effect is effectively zero. There is somewhat stronger evidence of a short-term boost to GDP (and equity markets) in the winning nation, but the longer-term effect remains minimal.
- In focusing on the narrow economic benefits of the World Cup, there is a risk of missing its broader worth. An alternative approach to evaluating the value of hosting or winning the World Cup is to use the ‘willingness to pay’ principle. Survey evidence suggests that many football fans (and the public at large) would be prepared to pay a substantial amount for the opportunity to host or win the World Cup.

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Big Business, Small Macro

The World Cup is Big Business

The FIFA World Cup is the largest sporting event globally, surpassing the Olympics, the Super Bowl, and the Cricket World Cup. According to FIFA, more than half the world's population – around 5 billion people – are estimated to have watched at least part of the 2022 World Cup Finals in Qatar, with 1.5 billion tuning in for the final between Argentina and France.¹

With more teams, more venues, and more matches, the 2026 World Cup is likely to surpass the 2022 Finals in terms of size. Starting on June 11 and running until July 19, the 2026 Finals will feature 48 teams (up from 32 in 2026), 104 games (up from 64), and total stadium capacity of 7.2 million (up from 3.4mn). The US will host 78 games, while Mexico and Canada will each host 13.

In addition to its global reach, football (or 'soccer') is increasingly popular in the US, with 10% of US sports fans now citing it as their favorite sport, behind American Football (36%) and Basketball (17%) but ahead of Baseball (9%).

With over 5 billion viewers anticipated worldwide and a live audience of up to 7.2 million, the World Cup is not only a major sporting occasion, it is also a major commercial event, with important financial implications for corporates across a wide range of sectors, including sporting apparel, hospitality, and beverages.

Our Equity analysts expect that the main beneficiaries will include European and US Consumer Staples (ABI, TAP, STZ, HEIN, CARL); European Consumer Discretionary (ADSGn, PUMG); US Retail (ASO, DKS); US Softlines & Apparel (NKE); US Lodging and Leisure (H, MAR, HLT); US Internet (ABNB); and US Airlines.

Hosting the World Cup: Big Business, Small Macro

Although the World Cup Finals will be a major commercial event, with important implications for many companies, it does not necessarily follow that the macroeconomic impact on the host nation(s) will be substantial or long-lasting.

FIFA has argued that the World Cup will drive economic and consumer activity beyond that of any previous tournament, resulting in a boost to US GDP of \$17.2 billion (around 0.2% of quarterly GDP). However, academic research into major sporting events has generally found that the economic advantages are modest, and usually fall well short of the optimistic 'ex ante' estimates often promoted by event advocates and organizing committees.²

Specific types of economic activity are likely to receive a significant boost – for instance, past World Cups have been associated with an increase in tourist arrivals. Nevertheless,

¹ The total viewership for the 2022 final was boosted by the high quality of the match, with many people tuning in as the game progressed. The match ended with a score of 3-3 after extra time, before Argentina won on penalties.

² For example, Yushan (2024), looking at FIFA World Cup Finals and Summer Olympics, found that, although there is evidence of positive 'urban regeneration' effects on the immediate localities, the direct GDP impact is often statistically insignificant.

several factors are likely to limit the overall macroeconomic impact on the host countries:

- **Only part of the economic benefit accrues to the host country.** The vast majority of the >5 billion people expected to watch part of the World Cup Finals will do so without ever setting foot in the US, Mexico or Canada. While more beer will be bought and more football-related merchandise will be purchased as a consequence of the World Cup, most of that beer and most of the merchandise will not be purchased in the host countries. And, even if it is purchased in the host countries, much of it will have been imported.
- **Additional spending or diverted spending?** A separate issue is whether the World Cup-related spending on goods and services in the host nations represents genuinely incremental spending that would not have occurred otherwise, or whether it has merely been diverted from other types of expenditure. It is also likely that the World Cup will ‘crowd out’ other types of spending – e.g., regular tourists avoiding host cities due to anticipated congestion and price surges.
- **Jam today, less tomorrow?** Even if hosting the World Cup Finals brings economic benefits in the short term, these gains may fade over the longer term as spending patterns return to their pre-Finals levels.
- **Size matters.** If one thinks of the World Cup Finals as delivering a roughly fixed boost to output in real cash terms, then the effect on the host country’s GDP growth will also depend on the size of its GDP. For this World Cup, there are three host countries rather than one, and the combined size of these nations is much larger than previous hosts (around 30% of global GDP at market prices – US (26%), Canada (2%) and Mexico (2%) – versus only 0.2% of global GDP in the case of Qatar).

The Economic Effects of the World Cup — A Bigger Boost from Winning than Hosting

To determine the economic effects of hosting a World Cup, we compare the GDP performance of the host nation(s) to a sample of 50 developed and emerging market economies for every World Cup since 1982 (11 Finals in total; [Exhibit 1](#)).³ We use the [Callaway and Sant’Anna](#) (2021) staggered difference-in-difference (DiD) approach to estimate the effects of hosting the World Cup Finals on real GDP.⁴

³ We exclude the period before 1982 partly due to data availability, but mainly because the World Cup did not achieve its current global status until the 1980s, making earlier Finals less comparable.

⁴ Unlike the standard DiD two-way fixed effect estimator (TWFE), Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) is designed for dealing with multi-event studies where the treatment and control groups vary over time. Specifically, it is structured to avoid the “forbidden comparisons” problem inherent in standard TWFE estimators, where already treated observation units – World Cup hosts or winners in this case – are used as controls in latter periods, a flaw that can bias results.

For each World Cup at time t , we estimate the treatment effect, denoted $ATT(c,t)$, of a country c hosting or winning that World Cup through an Outcome Regression. And after estimating $ATT(c,t)$ across all World Cups (t ’s), we take a simple average of these parameters to obtain our final estimates.

Exhibit 1: World Cup Host Nations and Winners Since 1982

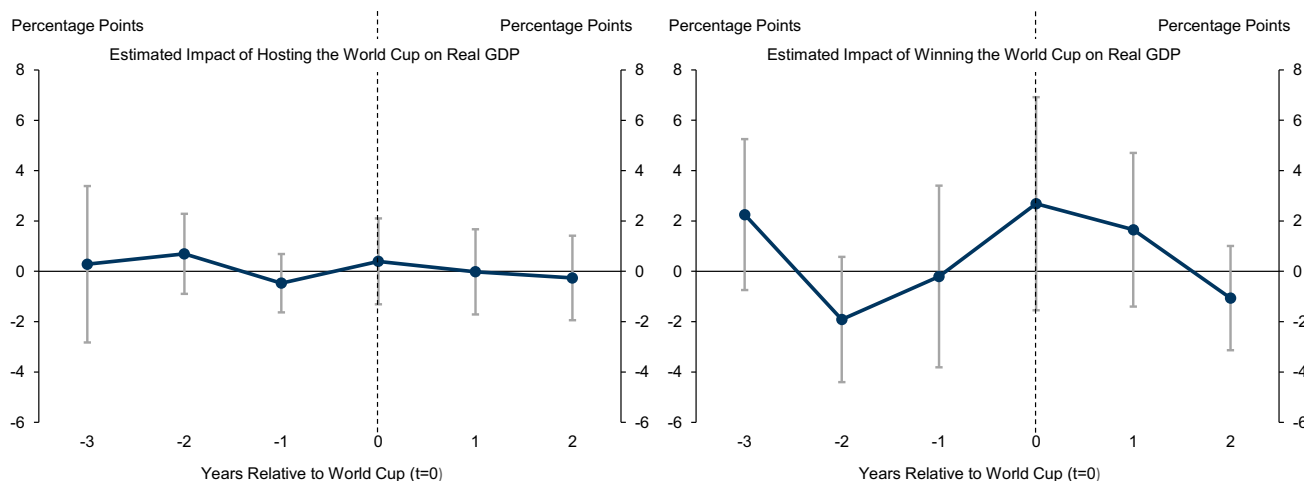
Year	Host (s)	Winner
1982	Spain	Italy
1986	Mexico	Argentina
1990	Italy	(West) Germany
1994	United States	Brazil
1998	France	France
2002	Japan and South Korea	Brazil
2006	Germany	Italy
2010	South Africa	Spain
2014	Brazil	Germany
2018	Russia	France
2022	Qatar	Argentina
2026	United States, Canada and Mexico	-

Source: FIFA

Our results imply that there is a marginally positive but not statistically significant effect on the real GDP of the host nation during the year the World Cup takes place and the long-run effect is effectively zero ([Exhibit 2](#)).

The notably wide confidence intervals surrounding our results are due to the limited sample size (just 11 observations) and the considerable diversity of experiences within this group. For instance, GDP was exceptionally strong in South Korea around the 2002 World Cup, weak in Mexico around the 1986 World Cup, and exceptionally volatile in Qatar around the 2022 World Cup.

We use the same methodology to estimate the effects of winning the World Cup and find slightly stronger evidence of a short-term increase in GDP for the winning nation. However, this short-term uplift remains within the margin of error – and is distorted by the exceptionally strong performance of Argentina around the 1986 World Cup. Moreover, the longer-term impact is minimal.

Exhibit 2: We Find Slightly Stronger Evidence of a Short-term Increase in GDP for the Winning Nation Relative to Hosts, But Results are not Statistically Significant

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

In previous research, our Equity strategists have also found evidence that the winning team's equity market tends to outperform in the weeks following the World Cup final. On average, the victor has outperformed the global market by 3.5% in the first month, although the outperformance fades significantly after three months.

Valuing World Cup Success: The 'Willingness to Pay' Principle

Empirical studies that attempt to capture the economic benefits of hosting or winning the World Cup can be fairly accused of knowing the price of everything, but the value of nothing. After all, for many football fans, football is 'more important than life and death'.⁵ An alternative approach to measuring the effects of hosting or winning the World Cup is to try to value the 'feel-good effect' or 'psychic income' derived from these outcomes.

If this seems woolly or unscientific, ask yourself the following question: "How much would you personally pay to see your country win the World Cup?" Many football fans would be willing to spend a considerable sum to witness such an outcome.

Although research attempting to quantify the value of hosting or winning the World Cup in this way remains limited, what findings there are suggest that the public are willing to sacrifice a considerable amount for both:

- Kavetsos and Szymanski (2010), based on survey evidence, find that, although the long-term financial return on investment from hosting a World Cup (or other major sporting event) may be limited, the 'willingness-to-pay' (WTP) for the sense of national pride and happiness generated by these events is large and significant.
- Bakkenbüll and Dilger (2015), drawing on survey data gathered during the 2014 World Cup, found that Germans were, on average, prepared to pay €23 each (equivalent to €32 today) if Germany were to become World Champion. Interestingly, the average sum respondents were willing to pay increased as Germany progressed through the tournament.
- Morgan and Whitehead (2015), utilizing data from two US nationwide surveys, found that respondents were willing to pay in additional taxes an amount equivalent to twice the cost required to fund a national program aimed at increasing the likelihood of future World Cup success.

Sadly for the authors, there appears little prospect of the Republic of Ireland or Gambia ever winning the World Cup. But we can still dream ...

Kevin Daly and Mambuna Njie

⁵ Bill Shankly, former Liverpool manager: "Some people think football is a matter of life and death. I assure you, it's much more serious than that."

World Cup Statistics: A Concise Collection

5,000,000,000. The number of people estimated to have watched some part of the 2022 World Cup Finals, with 1.5 billion viewers tuning in for the final between Argentina and France.

173,850. The largest match attendance at a World Cup: Uruguay v Brazil, Maracanã Stadium, Rio de Janeiro, 1950 Finals.

300. The lowest match attendance recorded: Romania vs. Peru, 1930 World Cup Finals.

210. The total number of countries that have ever taken part in the World Cup, including qualifiers, with 80 nations appearing in at least one Finals. Several of these countries no longer exist, including Yugoslavia (Semi-Finalists in 1930 and 1962) and the Dutch East Indies (1938 Finals).

Fifty-six. The fastest red card in World Cup history, ‘awarded’ to the Uruguayan defender José Batista, who was sent off 56 seconds into Uruguay’s match against Scotland in the 1986 FIFA World Cup.

Forty-five. The age of Egypt’s goalkeeper, Essam El-Hadary, the oldest player ever to appear in the World Cup Finals, during the 2018 tournament. He saved a penalty in his final match.

Forty-four. The longest gap in years between successive titles (Italy, 1938–1982).

Twenty-six. The number of matches Lionel Messi has played in World Cup Finals, the most of any player. As a member of Argentina’s squad for the 2026 Finals, he appears set to add to this record total.

Twenty-three. The number of times that Brazil has qualified for the World Cup Finals, the only team to have participated in every set of Finals since the tournament began in 1930.

Seventeen. The age of Brazilian star Pelé, the youngest world cup winner, when he played in the 1958 World Cup for Brazil. He scored two goals in the final against Sweden.

Sixteen. The highest number of total goals scored by a player in World Cup Finals, achieved by German striker Miroslav Klose, across four tournaments (2002–2014).

Thirteen. The most goals scored in a single tournament, by French striker Just Fontaine in the 1958 World Cup.

Twelve. The highest number of goals scored in a single match in the World Cup Finals, when Austria beat Switzerland 7–5 in the 1954 World Cup.

Eleven. The number of seconds (10.89, to be precise) it took Türkiye’s Hakan Şükür to score the fastest goal in the World Cup Finals, against South Korea in the 2002 third-place match. The quickest goal in a final was scored by Johan Neeskens for the Netherlands after 90 seconds in 1974, though his team went on to lose the match 2–1 to West Germany.

Ten. The most goals ever scored by one team in a World Cup Finals match, when Hungary beat El Salvador 10–1 in 1954. They also beat South Korea 9–0 in the same tournament.

Nine. The number of goals scored in the longest penalty shoot-out in World Cup Finals, in which Sweden beat Romania 5–4 in the 1994 quarter-final. The record for the longest shoot-out ever recorded in professional football is 56 shots, set in the match between F.C. Dimona and Shimshon Tel Aviv in 2024.

Eight. The total number of countries that have ever won a World Cup: Brazil (5 times), Germany (4), Italy (4), Argentina (3), France (2), Uruguay (2), England (1), and Spain (1).

Seven. The number of goals Germany scored against hosts Brazil in their 7-1 victory during the 2014 World Cup Semi-Final – the largest margin ever in the knock-out stages of the tournament.

Six. The number of times the defending champion has been eliminated in the Group Stage of the subsequent tournament: Italy (1950), Brazil (1966), France (2002), Italy (2010), Spain (2014), and Germany (2018). Only two teams have ever managed to retain their title – Italy (1934-38) and Brazil (1958-62) – leading to what is known as the “winners’ curse”.

Five. The number of World Cup titles won by Brazil (1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, 2002). Germany and Italy have both won four.

Four. The number of times the police had to intervene on the pitch to break up violent clashes between players during the 1962 Finals clash between Chile and Italy – subsequently known as ‘The Battle of Santiago’. Despite the violence and repeated police intervention, only two players received red cards.

Three. The number of times the Netherlands have made it to the World Cup final without winning (1974, 1978, 2010). Also, the most World Cup titles held by a single player (Pelé in 1958, 1962, 1970).

Two. The distance in meters by which Roberto Baggio, Italy’s star player and regular penalty taker, missed the target in the decisive penalty of the 1994 World Cup Final shoot-out, sealing his team’s defeat to Brazil.

One. The number of dogs to appear in the World Cup Finals. During the 1962 clash between Brazil and England, with the teams locked at 1-1, a stray dog invaded the pitch, evading players from both sides, before urinating on one of the English players. Following the dog’s intervention, Brazil scored two additional goals and won the match 3-1. The dog was adopted by Brazilian player Garrincha, who took him home to Brazil.

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